

I CREATE AS I SPEAK

Jewish magic and mysticism

While much magic was condemned in the Tanakh (Hebrew Bible), it was practiced during the medieval period by people at all levels of Jewish society, including rabbis. Even certain stories in the Tanakh depict leaders performing acts of magic: for instance, in the story of Moses, Aaron casts down his rod before the Pharaoh and it magically transforms into a snake (see p.28). The Babylonian Talmud, a sacred Jewish text, also contains references to magic in the form of spells, incantations, and the use of amulets.

The language of enchantment

Words were a key part of medieval Jewish magic. According to Jewish tradition, the Hebrew language has a divine origin and its letters have creative power. In the Tanakh, for example, God brings the world into existence simply by pronouncing words. Some

Jewish people believed that the right combination of words and letters could work magic and be used for anything from defeating demons to making prophecies. The letters of the names of God and the angels were considered especially potent. Some spells actively built on religious wording: in one text, magic words were added to a daily prayer to make a series of spells with specific aims, such as the raising of the dead. The strong relationship between magical and religious words persisted for centuries, particularly in the Jewish mystical tradition known as Kabbalah (see pp.88–89, 136–139).

Jewish scholars of magic were much influenced by the study of ancient Aramaic—the day-to-day language of Israel in the Second Temple Period (539 BCE–70 CE) and the language of the Talmud. Some argue that the most famous magic word of all, “Abracadabra!,” even comes from the Aramaic *avra k’davra* meaning “I create as I speak.”

Books of magic

Many Jewish women were well versed in the magic used for dealing with everyday issues such as illness or infertility. In contrast, rabbis and other scholars—typically men—practiced learned magic, which during the medieval period was increasingly written down in books of magic. Books such as the *Sepher ha-Yashar* (“Book of the Upright”), *Raza Rabba* (“The Great Secret”), and *Sepher ha-Razim* (“Book of Secrets”) gave recipes for acts such as healing, stimulating love, bringing luck, causing pain, and banishing demons.

Talismans and amulets

Many Jewish people in the medieval period believed in *shedim*, evil spirits that brought suffering; a key figure of fear was the night demon Lilith, who preyed upon children and women in childbirth.



▲ The magic star

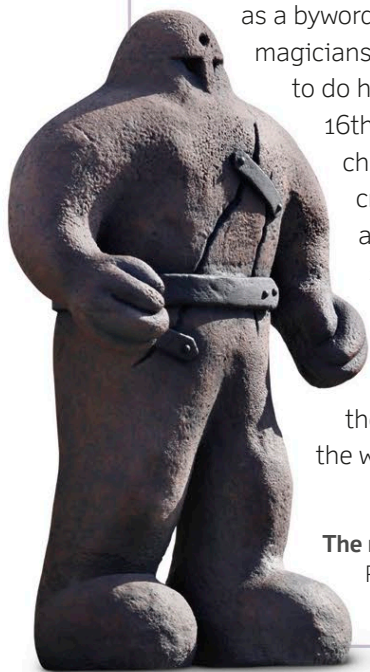
The star-shaped Seal of Solomon and the six-pointed Star of David, shown here on the St. Petersburg Codex (the oldest known complete text of the Tanakh, c.1010), were often viewed as powerful magical symbols.

IN CONTEXT

Living clay

Golems were sad creatures that were believed to be magically brought to life from clay by chanting the names of God. However, because they were not created by God they had no power to speak, and even today “golem” is sometimes used

as a byword for “stupid.” While some magicians were said to create golems to do household chores, a famous 16th-century legend from Prague chronicles how a golem was created by the Maharal to stop anti-Semitic attacks. Golems supposedly had the word *emet* (truth) inscribed on their foreheads, and could be reduced to dust by removing the first letter, which changed the word to *met* (death).



The mythical golem of 16th-century Prague has been recreated in this modern-day statue.